

Complete Swim Drill Guide

Catch-Up Drill

Swim freestyle with one arm extended until the recovering arm catches up. This improves body position, timing, and a long, efficient stroke.

Fingertip Drag

During freestyle recovery, lightly drag your fingertips across the water. This encourages a high elbow recovery and relaxed arm movement.

6-Kick Switch

Kick on one side for six kicks, then take one stroke and rotate to the other side. Focus on body rotation and balance.

Head-Lead Balance

Swim with your arms at your sides while keeping your body flat and balanced. This improves body position.

Single-Arm Freestyle

Swim using only one freestyle arm while the other remains extended or at your side. Helps improve catch and rotation.

Fist Swim

Swim freestyle with closed fists. This forces you to use your forearms for propulsion and improves feel for the water.

Tarzan Swim

Swim freestyle while keeping your head above the water. Improves strength, body position, and sighting ability.

Pull with Buoy

Place a pull buoy between your legs and swim using only your arms. Focus on a strong catch and pull.

Breathing Every 3

Breathe every third stroke while swimming freestyle to improve bilateral breathing and rhythm.

Descend Stroke Count

Try to take fewer strokes each length while maintaining or increasing speed.

Body Dolphin

Perform butterfly dolphin kicks with your arms extended in front. Focus on generating movement from your core and hips.

Single-Arm Butterfly

Swim butterfly using only one arm. This helps isolate timing and catch technique.

3-3-3 Drill

Swim 3 strokes right arm only, 3 strokes left arm only, then 3 full butterfly strokes.

Right Arm Fly

Swim butterfly using only your right arm while focusing on body rhythm.

Left Arm Fly

Swim butterfly using only your left arm while focusing on body rhythm.

Fly with 2 Kicks per Pull

Perform two dolphin kicks for every butterfly pull to reinforce proper timing.

Fly Kick on Back

Kick butterfly on your back with your arms streamlined. Helps develop a strong dolphin kick.

Butterfly with Fins

Wear fins while swimming butterfly to focus on body wave and timing.

Breathing Every Other Stroke

Breathe every second butterfly stroke to develop rhythm and endurance.

Fly Drill/Swim

Alternate drill and full butterfly swimming, usually by 25 or 50.

2-Kick 1-Pull

Perform two breaststroke kicks for every arm pull. Emphasizes kick power and timing.

Breast Kick on Back

Lie on your back and perform only the breaststroke kick to isolate kick mechanics.

Glide Focus

Hold a streamlined glide after every breaststroke kick before beginning the next stroke.

Breast Timing Drill

Practice the sequence: Pull → Breathe → Kick → Glide.

Pullout Practice

Practice the breaststroke pullout after each push-off: streamline, dolphin kick, pull-down, recovery, breakout.

Fast Recovery Drill

Focus on recovering the hands quickly back to streamline after every pull.

Narrow Kick Drill

Keep the kick narrow while maintaining power and proper foot position.

Breast Drill/Swim

Alternate breaststroke drills with full swimming.

Stroke Count Focus

Count your strokes each length and work toward greater efficiency.

Kick-Pull Separation

Pause briefly between the kick and the next pull to reinforce proper breaststroke timing.

Single-Arm Backstroke

Swim using only one backstroke arm to improve rotation and catch.

Rotation Drill

Emphasize rotating the shoulders and hips together during backstroke.

Head-Still Drill

Keep your head completely still while swimming backstroke.

Back Kick

Perform only the backstroke flutter kick while maintaining body position.

Double-Arm Backstroke

Pull with both arms simultaneously to improve body awareness and timing.

Catch-Up Back

Pause one arm overhead until the recovering arm reaches it before beginning the next pull.

Underwater Dolphin to Breakout

Push off in streamline, perform underwater dolphin kicks, then execute a smooth breakout.

Back Drill/Swim

Alternate backstroke drills with full swimming.

IM Order Drill

Practice Butterfly → Backstroke → Breaststroke → Freestyle in the correct IM order.

IM Drill

Alternate different IM technique drills while maintaining proper stroke order.

Transition Practice

Practice only the turns between IM strokes to improve legal and efficient transitions.

Underwater Focus

Concentrate on streamlined underwater kicks and strong breakouts after every wall.

Stroke Drill

Choose one stroke and focus on one technical aspect throughout the repeat.

Fly-to-Back Turns

Practice the butterfly-to-backstroke transition with a legal two-hand touch and quick rotation.

Back-to-Breast Turns

Practice rotating onto the breast before touching the wall and performing a legal breaststroke pullout.

Breast-to-Free Turns

Practice a legal two-hand touch followed by a quick freestyle turn and streamline.

IM Kick

Kick each stroke in IM order while maintaining proper technique.

Stroke Technique Choice

Choose one stroke and focus on improving a specific skill such as catch, kick, timing, or body position.

Fast Breakouts

Push off underwater and carry as much speed as possible into the first stroke.

Underwater Dolphins

Perform strong dolphin kicks underwater in a tight streamline.

Race Finish Practice

Sprint into the wall while timing the finish without gliding.

Dive and Breakout

Practice starts followed by powerful underwater kicks and a clean breakout.

Explosive Push-Offs

Focus on generating maximum power from every wall.

Sprint Kick

Kick at maximum effort while maintaining proper body position.

High Tempo Swimming

Swim with a faster-than-normal stroke rate while maintaining technique.

Build to Sprint

Begin each repeat at an easy pace and gradually increase speed until sprinting at the finish.

Stroke Count Sprint

Sprint while keeping your stroke count as low and efficient as possible.

Reaction Starts

Practice reacting quickly to the starting signal and executing a clean dive.

Long Stroke Count

Focus on taking long, efficient strokes with fewer strokes per length.

Breathing Pattern

Practice breathing every 3, 5, or 7 strokes to improve breathing control.

Descend

Swim each repeat faster than the previous one.

Technique Focus

Choose one technical skill and concentrate on it for the entire repeat.

Negative Split

Swim the second half of each repeat faster than the first half.

Smooth Tempo

Maintain a smooth, consistent stroke rate throughout the repeat.

Kick

Complete the repeat using only kicking.

Efficiency Focus

Concentrate on maximizing distance per stroke while minimizing wasted movement.

Pull with Paddles

Use hand paddles (and optionally a pull buoy) to develop upper-body strength and improve catch mechanics.

IM Order Sprint

Sprint each stroke in IM order while maintaining excellent technique and transitions.